

After I'd cleaned up the mess, I went back to my study and did some more reading.

It turns out that Japan has been top of the international student rankings since surveys began.

To find out why, the OECD (Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development) wrote a research report analysing why Japanese students were consistently ahead of their peers.

What they found had a lot of tie-backs to the honourable mealtime mindset:

'People work very hard in Japan largely to earn the respect and admiration of their colleagues. They do not work hard for personal distinction, but rather for the good of the group . . . there's a shared belief that if the individual works tirelessly for the group, the group will reciprocate.'

In other words, the culture that Japanese kids grow up in is that everyone pitches in.

Not for money.

Not because they'll get lollies later.

They work hard for each other because they're part of a group and it's the honourable thing to do.

And that's the key for your kids. They should be expected to pitch in and help out with dinner for free . . . with their only payoff being that they're fed.

So let's take everything we've covered here . . . and put it all together.

Tying it all together: the Barefoot Money Meal

One of the cornerstones of this book—in fact, one of the 'big things' to get right—is having a regular meal together:

I call it the Barefoot Money Meal.